

Group name

Enter your details :

Section

Instructions/information: Following are some exercises that relate to a reading you have been assigned. Please refer to your notes as you answer them. You are encouraged to confer with your group mates as you put down your thoughts.

Reflect and discuss (A)

 1.

Read the passage below, making note of any important points and definitions.

RESEARCH ARGUMENTS

Real research involves more than just amassing information on a topic; we argued that it means developing solutions to problems you and your readers care about. Likewise, sharing the results of your research involves more than just giving your readers a “data dump” that says, Here are some facts about my topic; it means explaining your problem and justifying your solution in a research argument. In a research argument, you make a claim, back it with reasons supported by evidence, acknowledge and respond to other views, and sometimes explain your principles of reasoning. There’s nothing arcane about these things: you do them in every conversation that inquires thoughtfully into an unsettled issue.

1. A **claim** is an assertion (which can be a single sentence or more) that demands support: *Climate change is threatening coastal cities; Toni Morrison’s most important novel is Beloved*. Your main claim is the assertion your whole research argument supports. Some call this assertion your **thesis**.
2. A **reason** is an assertion that supports a claim: [*Because*] climate change is causing ocean levels to rise; [*Because*] in *Beloved*, Morrison’s major themes find their fullest development.
3. **Evidence** is: data deployed to support a reason. Unlike a claim or a reason, evidence is not always

framed as an assertion: a data table documenting rising ocean levels over the past decade or quotations from *Beloved* illustrating Morrison’s major themes would be forms of evidence.

These terms can be confusing, because a reason is also a subclaim that can be supported by more reasons and because both reasons and evidence are kinds of support.

ACKNOWLEDGING AND RESPONDING TO ANTICIPATED QUESTIONS AND OBJECTIONS

Careful readers will question every part of your argument, so you must anticipate as many of their questions as you can, and then acknowledge and respond to the most important ones. For example, when readers consider the claim that schools should make foreign-language instruction a priority, they may wonder if doing that might detract from the teaching of other subjects. If you think readers might ask that question, you would be wise to acknowledge and respond to it.

CONNECTING CLAIMS AND REASONS WITH WARRANTS

Even when your readers agree that a reason is true, they may still object that it’s not relevant to your claim. Consider this argument:

‘We are facing significantly higher health care costs in Europe and North America_{claim} because climate change is moving the line of extended hard freezes steadily northward_{reason}’

Readers might accept the truth of that reason but question its relevance to the claim, asking: *What do higher health costs have to do with hard freezes? I don't see the connection.* To answer, you must offer a *general* principle that justifies relating your *particular* reason to your *particular* claim:

‘When an area has fewer hard freezes, it must pay more to combat new diseases carried by subtropical insects no longer killed by those freezes.’

Like all warrants, this one says that if a general circumstance exists (an area has fewer hard freezes), then we can infer a general consequence (that area will have higher costs to combat new diseases). The logic behind all warrants is that if a generalization is true or reasonable, then so must be specific instances of it.

Excerpted from Wayne C et al. Booth. *The craft of research*. University of Chicago press, 2016

Reflect and discuss (B)

2.

1. Elementary schools should make teaching foreign languages a priority because we acquire languages best and most easily when we are young.
2. Elementary schools should make teaching foreign languages a priority because we acquire languages best and most easily when we are young. In fact, those who begin second languages as adults rarely attain the level of fluency of those who learn them as children. Teaching foreign languages at the elementary-school level also contributes to children's ethical development, because it fosters an awareness of cultures and societies beyond their own.
3. Elementary schools should make teaching foreign languages a priority because we acquire languages best and most easily when we are young. In fact, those who begin second languages as adults rarely attain the level of fluency of those who learn them as children. In a study of over one hundred second-language learners, Jones (2013) identified an inverse correlation between second-language proficiency and ...(see table 1).
4. "...despite their selfish belligerence, humans' rationality manifests itself in their capacity to understand the benefits of peace and order and, therefore, in their willingness to agree to set up an association, a State, a government which will facilitate peaceful coexistence. However, such an agreement does not suffice ... Even though people recognise that peace is better than war and universal respect of neighbours is preferable to feuding, each individual also recognises that his or her desires are best served by being unprincipled in a principled community. And if everyone prefers that all others are law-abiding while he or she cheats, steals, coerces and murders, then the agreement between people will be worthless and the 'war of all against all' will recommence. What is needed ...is something stronger than some agreement; individuals must agree to give up some of their rights to a higher authority (e.g. the State) so as to live in peace. " (Yanis Varoufakis, *Foundations of Economics*)
5. American higher education must curb escalating tuition costs, because the price of college is becoming an impediment to realizing the American dream. Today a majority of students leave college with a crushing debt burden. In 2013, nearly 70 percent of students borrowed money for college with loans averaging \$30,000, a debt that prevents many from buying a home, beginning a family, or pursuing a higher degree.
6. When an area has fewer hard freezes, it can expect higher medical costs to cope with diseases carried by subtropical insects that do not survive freezes. Europe and North America must thus expect higher health care costs because climate change is moving the line of extended hard freezes steadily north. In the last one hundred years, the line of hard freezes lasting more than two weeks has moved north at the rate of roughly...
7. A whale is more closely related to a hippopotamus than to a cow, because it shares more DNA with a hippopotamus. When a species shares more DNA with one species than it does with another, we infer that it is more closely related to the first.
8. The Russian Federation faces a falling standard of living, because its birthrate is only 13.2 per 1,000 and life expectancy for men is only about 63 years.
9. The Russian Federation faces a falling standard of living, because its birthrate is only 13.2 per 1,000 and life expectancy for men is only about 63 years. When a nation's labor force shrinks, its economic future is grim.

10. Contrary to popular belief, gun ownership in America was probably not widespread in the first half of the nineteenth century and before, because guns were rarely mentioned in wills. A review of 4,465 wills filed in seven states from 1750 to 1850 shows that only 11 percent mention a long gun or handgun.
11. In the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, valuable objects were listed in wills, so when someone failed to mention a valuable object in his will, he did not own one. Since guns were valuable but were rarely mentioned in wills before 1850, gun ownership must not have been widespread.
12. In the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, valuable objects were listed in wills, so when a will failed to mention such a valuable object, the person did not own one. Watson (1989) confirmed that to be the case. In a study of 1,356 wills filed in Cumberland County between 1750 and 1825, he found ...
13. Children aged 12-16 today are significantly more violent than their counterparts from a generation ago. Brown (2013) has shown that... Given these facts, it seems highly likely that violent video games are exerting a destructive influence on today's youth.
14. When children are constantly exposed to images of sadistic violence, they are influenced for the worse. Children aged 12-16 today are significantly more violent than their counterparts from a generation ago. Brown (2013) has shown that... Given these facts, it seems highly likely that violent video games are exerting a destructive influence on today's youth.
15. When children are constantly exposed to images of sadistic violence, they are influenced for the worse. Over the past decade, video games have become a major source of children's exposure to violent imagery. Jones (2014) shows that... Given these facts, it seems highly likely that violent video games are exerting a destructive influence on today's youth, making them significantly more violent than their counterparts from a generation ago.

Read the passage below, making note of any important points and definitions.

BUILDING A COMPLEX ARGUMENT OUT OF SIMPLE ONES

1. Claim: What do you want me to believe? What's your point?
2. Reasons: Why do you say that? Why should I agree?
3. Warrants: General principles connecting claims and reasons. How does that follow? What's your logic? Can you explain your reasoning?
4. Evidence: How do you know? Can you back it up?
5. Acknowledgment and response

These five elements constitute a "basic" argument, but research arguments are more complex.

- We almost always support a claim with two or more reasons, each of which must be supported by its own additional reasons and evidence and perhaps justified by its own warrant. Since readers think of many alternatives and objections to any complex argument, careful researchers typically have to respond to a number of them.
- Moreover, each reason, warrant, or response to an objection (all of which are statements or assertions) may itself have to be treated as a subclaim and supported by its own argument. Only the evidence "stands alone," but even then you may have to explain where you got it, why you think it's reliable, and how it supports your reason- and that may require yet another argument.

And finally, most arguments also include background, definitions, explanations of issues that readers might not understand, and so on. If, for example, you were making an argument about the relationship between inflation and money supply to readers not familiar with economic theory, you would have to explain how economists understand those concepts. Serious arguments are complex constructions.

To accept your claim, readers must accept your definitions, because definitions are crucial warrants: if you are researching nicotine addiction, your readers must understand what you mean by that term. Does it mean just a strong craving, a craving that some people can't resist, or a craving that no one can? You can find definitions ranging from a few lines in a dictionary to pages in a medical reference work. But regardless of what those sources say, readers tend to redefine terms they encounter to suit their own views. Cigarette manufacturers long argued that cigarettes are not addictive because some people can quit; their critics argued that cigarettes are addictive because more people can't.

When your argument hinges on the meaning of a term, define it to support your solution and offer a subordinate argument for your definition. Don't treat a dictionary definition as authoritative (never begin, "According to Webster's, 'addiction' means ..."). Be aware of plausible alternative definitions that you may need to acknowledge. If you use a technical term that also has a common meaning (like social class or theory), acknowledge that common

meaning and explain why you have adopted the technical one. Conversely, if you do not use a technical term as expert readers expect you to, acknowledge that and explain why you've opted for another meaning.

CREATING AN ETHOS BY THICKENING YOUR ARGUMENT

Readers judge your arguments not just by the reasons and evidence you offer but also by how well you anticipate and address their questions and concerns. By “thickening” your argument in this way, you earn the confidence of your readers, building up what is traditionally called your **ethos**: the character you project in your argument. Do you seem to be the sort of person who considers issues from all sides, who supports claims with evidence that readers accept, and who thoughtfully considers other points of view? Or do you seem to be someone who sees only one point of view and dismisses or even ignores the views of others?

When you acknowledge other views and explain your principles of reasoning in warrants, you give readers good reason to work *with* you in developing and testing new ideas. In the long run, the ethos you project in individual arguments hardens into your reputation, something every researcher must care about, because your reputation is the tacit sixth element in every argument you write. It answers the unspoken question, *Can I trust you?* That answer must be *Yes*.

QUALIFYING CLAIMS TO ENHANCE YOUR CREDIBILITY

Some new researchers think their claims are most credible when they are stated most forcefully. But nothing damages your ethos more than arrogant certainty. As para-

doxical as it seems, you make your argument stronger and more credible by modestly acknowledging its limits. You gain the trust of your readers when you acknowledge and respond to their views, showing that you have not only understood but considered their position. But you can lose that trust if you then make claims that overreach. Limit your claims to what your argument can actually support by qualifying their scope and certainty.

1. We conclude that the epicenter of the earthquake was fifty miles southwest of Tokyo, assuming the instrumentation was accurately calibrated.
2. We believe that aviation manufacturing will not match its late twentieth-century levels, unless new global conflicts increase military spending.

But every claim is subject to countless conditions, so mention only those that readers might plausibly think of. Scientists rarely acknowledge that their claims depend on the accuracy of their instruments, because everyone expects them to ensure that they are. But economists often acknowledge limits on their claims, both because their predictions are subject to changing conditions and because readers want to know which conditions to watch for.

Excerpted from Wayne C et al. Booth. *The craft of research*. University of Chicago press, 2016

Reflect and discuss (C)

 3.

1. Elementary schools should make foreign languages a priority because we acquire languages best and most easily when we are young. ...Of course, if schools increase the attention they give to foreign languages, quality of instruction in other subjects might decline. But little evidence exists to support that fear and much dispels it...
2. Some have argued that food can be addictive, but we are concerned here only with substances for which addiction is the norm.
3. Some have argued that food can be addictive, but we are concerned here only with substances for which addiction is the norm. Some who taste chocolate once may be unable to resist it thereafter, but their number is a fraction of those who are immediately addicted to crack cocaine after a single exposure. Chernowitz (1998) found that just one exposure resulted in ...
4. Although many believe that school uniforms help lower the incidence of violence in public schools, the evidence is at best weak because researchers have not controlled for other measures that have been instituted at the same time as uniforms and because the data reported are statistically suspect.
5. Today Franklin D. Roosevelt is revered as one of our most admired historical figures, but toward the end of his second term, he was quite unpopular, at least among certain segments of American society. Newspapers, for example, attacked him for promoting socialism, a sign that a modern administration is in trouble. In 1938, 70 percent of Midwest newspapers accused him of wanting the government to manage the banking system...Some have argued otherwise, including Nicholson (1983, 1992) and Wiggins (1973), both of whom offer anecdotal reports that Roosevelt was always in high regard, but these reports are supported

only by the memories of those who had an interest in deifying FDR. Unless it can be shown that the newspapers critical of Roosevelt were controlled by special interests, their attacks demonstrate significant popular dissatisfaction with Roosevelt's presidency.